

Medford School Committee Meeting

April 26, 2021

Remote Meeting by ZOOM

Regular Meeting: 6:00 PM

Join Zoom Meeting

<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/91506415713>

Meeting ID: 915 0641 5713

6:05 Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn read introduction.

I. Roll Call and Salute the Flag

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Mea, Melanie, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7 present 0 Absent

II. Approval of Minutes:

1. April 12, 2021 School Committee Meeting Motion to approve: Paulette Van der Kloot/Kathy Kreatz
Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Mea, Melanie, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7 yes 0 Absent Minutes approved

III. Approval of Bills/Transfer of Funds and Approval of Payrolls

Motion to approve: Paulette Van der Kloot/Kathy Kreatz

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Mea, Melanie, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7 yes 0 Absent / Payrolls approved

IV. Report of Secretary

1. Good of the Order - *Offered by Melanie Mclaughlin*

Category in Robert's Rules of order to check in with SC as a group to offer positives or things that need to be worked on

Paul Ruseau: I suggest that we all take a refresher course on Roberts Rules. Some members ask 6 or 7 questions in a row. WE can act better as a committee than a group approaching election.

Paulette Van der Kloot; Maybe a member can ask two questions and pass turn to another member. Our last meeting was 6 hours long. 23 meetings in March. We are inadvertently taking over the

roles of people we respect. We should not take up so much of their time with these meetings.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: I agree with you.

Melanie McLaughlin: These have been talked about and we need to address these items. MASC has an event to teach on Roberts Rules of order. More meetings for less time?

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Colin Bailey - Student rep on the call.

Kathy Kraetz: Sometimes I am unable to speak because other members speak so much and it gets late. It would be helpful if a member asks only one question at a time. I am not in favor of more frequent meetings. Admin. Will just be getting ready for meetings even more often.

Paulette Van der Kloot; vice chair, Melanie

Melanie McLaughlin : I am hoping through good of the order we can come up with better suggestions.

Paulette Van der Kloot: i would suggest a rotation for questions to see how that works. If there is a follow up point, that is fine, but not an additional question. Shake of head consensus.

All shake heads

V. Report of Committees

1. Behavioral Health and Special Education Subcommittee Meeting, April 15, 2021 - Melanie McLaughlin, Chair

Meeting with several members present; Paulette Van der Kloot in place of Mea Mustone along with Paul Ruseau. We have scheduled a presentation to the school committee on May 24 to put forth a recommendation for proposed policy. Next meeting in May. Meetings over the course of the year discussing building friendships and trauma informed schools. Common ground is a reverse inclusion model being used now - looking to create a syllabus for an actual course around doing this. Pursuing Best Buddies.

Motion to approve minutes: Paulette Van der Kloot second

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kretz, Mea Mustone, Melanie, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7 yes 0 Absent / Minutes approved

VI. Community Participation

Any citizen in the audience may be given permission to speak once at School Committee meetings

regarding any item on the agenda for up to three minutes on any one item.

A Community Participation portion of the agenda is established which will give any citizen the privilege of placing any item before the School Committee or be heard on any item. Any item to be presented must be submitted in writing to the Superintendent of Schools by the Wednesday noon prior to the scheduled meeting, with a maximum of five (5) minutes allowed for any one presentation

Public Participation Emails: Questions or comments can be submitted during the meeting by emailing medfordsc@medford.k12.ma.us. Those submitting must include the following information:

1. Your first and last name
2. Your Medford street address
3. Your question or comment

Parent, Maureen Ronayne, Topic: Dyslexia (up to five minutes)

One email submitted by William Giglio, Winthrop Street

Get email from Paulette Van der Kloot: requests that updates on news stories are not included in the SC meeting. When reciting Pledge, the flag be present.

Ms. Ronayne not on call.

VII. Report of Superintendent

1. Superintendent's Updates and Comments

Insert remarks here.

2. COVID-19 Public Health Update & MPS COVID-19 Testing Summary and Update - Nurse Supervisor Toni Wray, Ms. MaryAnn O'Connor - Board of Health & Mr. David Murphy

22.9 cases per day. 25 children less than 19 years tested positive between 4.18 - 4.25.

0.06 positivity rate in schools.

Testing resumed today in schools. Reminder to staff who received vaccines to continue to receive testing each week. Vaccinations can still spread viruses.

CDC: we remain in a complicated stage. More vaccinated each day but cases and hospitalizations increasing as well as cases with young people also increasing. Thanks to those who provided notification of travel plans. Following guidelines will help assure safety for all.

Melanie McLaughlin: I would like to ask about vaccine information.

Toni Wray: we are recommending students over 16 to obtain vaccinations. Pre Register through [mass.vacc](https://mass.vacc.gov)

site.

Melanie McLaughlin: Question, is families send vaccination records to nurses' offices?

Toni Wray: Yes we would love to have those records.

3. Update on FY 22 Budget Preparation - David Murphy

Brief deck: Insert here.

Simplified version of flowchart. Moving toward public meetings that will be COWs in upcoming weeks. This is an updated timeline of meetings: 5/3, 5/6, 5/14, 5/18, 5/19. We added a meeting at the end of the process. Calendar updates will be sent. 7:00 pm start time to accommodate for subcommittee meetings. Uncertainty as to how much funding is coming in. Comfortable with financial position approaching FY2021. Substantial deficits in revolving accounts due to diminished ability to generate revenue. We are not releasing a partial spending freeze. We are in a good position, but not overly favorable. Food services deficit. We have two internal meetings this week. Two major sources: ESSER 2 and ESSER 3 coming to the school district. As we get into spending priorities, all principals and debt heads asked for budgetary priorities. Looking to address learning gaps exacerbated by pandemic. Buckets with priority areas. Three categories;

Paul Ruseau: We passed a motion last summer to get updated binders to prepare for the budget. The binder is not correct. I am not saying 62.3 is not correct but the documents cannot be lies. The budget documents has to reflect what the budget was. People will say our budget was 61.3.

Dave Murphy: There is no intention to lie to the SC. the 62.3 was the operating budget made up of chapter 70 funding. There are other sources in the range of 2 million dollars. Also doesn't represent the covid relief funding. I wasn't here so I cannot speak to the inaccuracies. My team has spent a significant amount of time attempting to align the budget lines with the appropriate budget categories. Historically there have been salaries charged to the wrong lines that may look non-transparent. If there is a year where one account is short, a salary might be charged against another account. In the binder, you will see variability that doesn't represent a strategic decision on behalf of the district. It is a necessary correction that should be made with the purpose of transparency. 62.3 plus the external funds I don't want people thinking there is a binder of 62.3 and we spent an additional 10 without telling anyone.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Housekeeping comment. Curriculum. This wed from 4 to 5:30 Science and Fine arts. We would like to set up a meeting for tuesday, may 4 from 4 to 5:30 to discuss health/pe. This removes the later May meeting so we can discuss all curriculums before the budget meetings.

Jenny Graham: what is the city's allocation to the district this year?

Dave Murphy: I don't have it yet. Ongoing discussion with the city's finance team. I don't have an official number. The committee will vote on a request that will go to the city.

Jenny Graham: We have changed the process? The city used to provide numbers and we would work at it.

Dave Murphy: we are following the MA law

Jenny Graham: we need to be thinking of funds we didn't receive last year. Looking to restore the district from the layoffs and pink slips last year. I am looking to make sure we are funding what we missed out on last year: ms health, reading specialists and dyslexia. I hope we don't have pink slip this year. I hope we can do right across all the bargaining units that have gotten us through the pandemic. Cost of living increases.

Dave Murphy: Slide with 3 buckets:

2.1 M increase Coming regardless of any decision we have made. Fixed costs.

B and C involve some strategic decisions that can be made. Implications to that.

B: restoration of FTE's - making sure these positions are restored appropriately.

There is a range. There is a variability. Uncertainty exacerbated this year by an influx of spending that we don't yet have. Leaves us with more questions.

Not a time to panic but not a time to rejoice. If our increase is below 3m, that will be a challenge. If it is above 6m, we will have to make strategic decisions. In between, we can make sound investments to benefit students.

Melanie: Thank you for the powerpoint. Can you please send to the members? Conversation around process: we talked about the flowchart. The community may need more clarification to understand the process. Do we need the visual of what the process is and how it works? What is the status of that? Will they have it before May 3 when budget meetings start?

Dave Murphy: Beyond the flowchart in the presentation?

Back to slide: Is there information missing?

Melanie: Yes, how are decisions made? What happens if the committee votes yes/no? We had a very close vote on the budget last time. It wasn't clear to the public or to the committee members?

Dave Murphy: Under the city form of governance, if the question is what happens if the SC doesn't vote to approve on what the municipal government has appropriated? We would then consult with the MA department of revenue. There would be a government shutdown. The committee's role is making the initial request to the local government. The municipal government makes the spending decisions. IF the SC refuses to accept the budget from the gov, there would not be a plan b. It would not be a strategically prudent path to take. That is a doomsday scenario. I don't think that information would benefit the community. I am hesitant to incorporate more information into this presentation than is necessary. If the committee wants to articulate that, they are entitled to do that. My suggestion is adopt the budget appropriated and try to get additional funding.

Paul Ruseau: Deja vu here. I have literally watched videos of districts submitting budgets higher than what the municipality appropriates and the world doesn't come to an end.

Dave Murphy: I am saying refusing to adopt a budget is not prudent. Adopt the budget and lobby for more.

Paul Ruseau: if the mayor gives you a number, the sc votes yes and no on that number. That is the entirety of what we do. In other communities, we compile what the schools need. The municipality can approve it or not. We are talking about reading services not band uniforms. That is not a priority, that is essential to

sending kids out into the world. We need adaptive people. There are children on the other end not prepared to survive. I would feel better putting a number up for what we need. Every year, we send up an exact budget to match what city hall gives us. This is just not true. Other communities have figured this out. If the community is not willing to pay for it. I am tired talking about these priorities.

Dave Murphy: In this presentation we use the word necessity, not priority.

The presentation tonight says there is a range between 3.4 ? and 5.8m where we can make good decisions. If you want 6.3, I don't know why you wouldn't take that 5.8. I have a responsibility to tell you if we get a higher number, there will be a lot of planning to account for that money. By all means you can make that request. Understand we will operate if we don't get below 6 million dollars. We are working to be more transparent. I want to be clear, there are two stages of the process: you can make all the requests you want. Not taking what is appropriated is not in the best interest of anyone.

Paul Ruseau: Can we get an attorney onto the call who can answer the questions to these questions? It is not reality that people won't get paid. I need to have an answer as to what happens when we don't approve a budget that is adequate. We are still asking what will happen? I can't believe that no one has refused to adopt a budget.

Dave Murphy: I am happy to get you an attorney. I am an attorney who has experienced this. There are paths forward. In this form of government, there will not be a good option available. I am not saying there will be no options. I am not saying that the SC has to just vote on whatever the city hands over. It is not uncommon where SCs forget to take the second vote. Administratively, people get paid. There is a statute where the committee is expected to approve the budget. There might be something symbolic about just saying no but it is not of strategic value. More prudent strategy is to adopt it - still have two months to advocate for a supplemental budget. That constitutes best practice. We as admin. Don't want to spend money the city hasn't approved.

Jenny Graham: This two step practice is something Medford has not done before. It is time we start doing this. That means two votes. That allows the SC to tell the city government what we need to support students in our charge. Allows a way to acknowledge that we are doing all we can do with what we were given. I am supportive of the two step process and I am happy to have you on board to guide us to do better for Medford.

Dave Murphy: I am hearing that the SC wants the city to know exactly what the schools need funding for. There is also a reality, there are competing needs and a limited amount of funding, even with funding from the federal government.

3. Report on Summer Fun and Community Schools, Dr. Peter J. Cushing, Robert Maloney

Summer Fun: Will start on July 5 through August 13. 6 weeks of availability. All summer programs have staffing issues as well as pandemic induced exhaustion. Need appropriate nursing staff and support in place. There will be a cost increase to \$200 per week. We cannot accept walk-ins. We need negative covid tests prior to enrolling. The Summer Fun program will be moved to the Columbus School. We will have the opportunity to use the Tufts pool at Tufts park. CDC guidelines updated on Friday night. 3 feet apart. 6 feet while eating. Encourage all staff to get vaccinated asap. We will be ventilating interior spaces. Masks wearing are enforced however, masks don't work when wet.

GBL: pushing our athletic seasons until July 3. Fall season starts August 15. Medford Basketball summer camp runs through the varsity team. Boston Celtics interested in returning to Medford High to run camps.

Melanie McLaughlin : I am confused - is Mr. Maloney here?

Peter Cushing: he is supervising volleyball

Melanie McLaughlin: Do we know the status of what the cost is going to be for summer fun?

Peter Cushing: Right now we are charging 200 dollars per student. Includes cost of PPE. Initial conversations were capping at 75 campers due to limited staff. If we get more staff, we can get more campers.

Melanie McLaughlin: In the past, we made sure that all applications that MPS does not discriminate - make sure that children with disabilities are allowed to participate. Accessible and open to all. Mr. Petrellis was great about including this in the past. Building friendships between children with and without disabilities.

Peter Cushing: We welcome members of our community who might want to sponsor students. Applications should be ready at the end of this week. We can't have walk ups that people are accustomed to.

Melanie McLaughlin: Are there opportunities for teens to apply for positions as camp counselors?

Peter Cushing: Yes.

Melanie McLaughlin: How do counselors apply?

Peter Cushing: We will send it out to all students through district email? We may have lost counselors who needed to find employment elsewhere last summer.

Melanie: This is a great example of affordability and accessibility in our city.

4. Recommendation to approve 2021-2022 School Year Calendar PR/Melanie

Roll: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kretz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn 7/0 new calendar is approved

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Will that be up on our website soon?

Paul Ruseau: Thanks to everyone who did the work on that.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: Thanks to Suzi.

5. Update on discounted MBTA Bus Passes for Disadvantaged Students - David Murphy

We offer discounted mbta passes at \$30. We sell about 40 or 50 per month. We would like to offer as much access as possible. We have had internal discussions and have reached out to the MBTA about getting further discounts by buying passes in bulk. I am not that optimistic about the result of that conversation. We can reach out to other districts as well about procuring other passes. There would be a \$150k impact if we expand to cover all economically disadvantaged students. \$350K for all high school students. If there is a larger suite of offerings. It may be cost effective to expand the yellow bus to the high schools. We may want to take a look at that. Are there any other questions?

Jenny Graham: I would like to see what the options are for transportation when we discuss the

transportation budget. Maybe the MBTA buses are not the most cost effective method? We may consider late start times if we are not dependent on the MBTA. There may be a better option to pursue.

Melanie McLaughlin : I appreciate the time you have taken to meet with me as well. In the past teachers have been funding these passes?

Dave Murphy: The teachers have done some fundraising to provide for students. Testament to how dedicated they are to students. Not a prudent long term strategy. We should never expect that of teachers. This is a significant financial commitment. We need to consider all the potential options. We don't want the \$300 the students need to spend on T passes to prevent access to education or other opportunities?

Paul Ruseau: When I spoke of the budget we actually need, this is one of those items I am referring to. Failure of society. School should be free. I don't know why this would not be on the list. I appreciate your running the numbers on this. We can build a budget that shows the residents of Medford what the budget does provide. If we can't get more revenue, this is something we are taking away from your kids. Harder to take this away from kids.

Leticha Rocha: Member of the public with raised hand: I see that Mr. Murphy has discussed the passes for disadvantaged high school students. Equitable transportation for all high school students is necessary. Only north medford gets bus service. MBTA is not safe or reliable for our students. Many south medford students struggle to get to school on time due to the MBTA. Facing suspension. This district likes to claim they are for equity but you need to provide all students a way of getting to school. We need action not performative gestures.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: Back on call after internet problems.

Melanie McLaughlin : Regarding the budget meeting, the information should be disaggregated. How many econ. Disadvantaged students at the high school? How many outside the two mile radius? That is required by law. I was told in the past that we do provide transportation for students outside 2 miles. For homeless students, we are required to provide transportation. Econ disadv/total high school/total outside two mile radius

VIII. Old Business

IX. Communications

X. New Business

1. Resolution in Support of Expedited COVID-19 Vaccinations for Students

-Offered by Jenny Graham and Paul Ruseau

Approved at the last meeting. On agenda in error.

2. Whereas the current School Committee Policy GCA - PROFESSIONAL STAFF POSITIONS states:

All professional staff positions in the school system will be created initially by the School Committee. It is the Committee's intent to activate a sufficient number of positions to accomplish the school system's goals and objectives and to provide for the equitable staffing of each school building. Although such positions may remain temporarily unfilled, only the Committee may abolish a position it has created.

Each time a new position is established by the Committee, the Superintendent will present for the Committee's approval a job description for the position, which specifies the jobholder's qualifications and the job's performance responsibilities. The Superintendent will maintain a comprehensive set of job descriptions for all positions.

NOTE: Job descriptions for professional staff positions are available for review in the office of the Superintendent.

Be it resolved that the School Committee amends policy GCA - Professional Staff Positions to ensure transparency, relevancy, and accountability across all professional staff job functions.

All professional staff positions in the school system will be created initially by the School Committee. It is the Committee's intent to activate a sufficient number of positions to accomplish the school system's goals and objectives and to provide for the equitable staffing of each school building. Professional Staff is defined as department heads, central office staff, nursing,

The Superintendent will maintain a comprehensive list of positions and set of job descriptions for all positions. All job descriptions will be reviewed every three years and presented to the School Committee for approval. Job descriptions will contain a last reviewed date. The Superintendent will establish a review cycle for all position descriptions within 60 days of the adoption of this policy. The initial review cycle will last for no longer than three years and conclude by September 1, 2024.

Effective September 1, 2021, the comprehensive list and current job descriptions for professional staff positions are available for review by the public on the MPS website.

Each time a new position is established by the Committee, the Superintendent will present for the Committee's approval a job description for the position, which specifies the jobholder's qualifications and the job's performance responsibilities.

Although such positions may remain temporarily unfilled, only the Committee may abolish a position it has created.

All positions unfilled for the entire prior school year will be reported to the Committee annually no later than June 1st, with an explanation for the vacancy.

All positions that remain unfilled for more than two consecutive school years will be presented to the Committee to be abolished no later than June 1st. In the event the Superintendent wishes to maintain any positions that have been unfilled for more than two consecutive school years the Superintendent must explain the rationale and plan to fill the position and get approval from the Committee to continue the unfilled position for an additional year.

- *Offered by Jenny Graham and Paul Ruseau (Tabled from 4.12.2021 School Committee Meeting)*

Jenny Graham: Policy on rules and responsibilities appears to be outdated as education shifts. Goal is to provide transparency to the community.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Question as to the timeline. Sept. 1 may not be realistic. Curious as to reaction from Central Administration. I find it confusing and prescriptive. I am wondering if we can simplify it to make it more accessible.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: I agree with the premise but also agree that it is confusing. I would like to ask the admin about the timeline.

Jenny Graham: Sept. 1 only requires a list. We don't expect changes to every job description at the same time. 3 year roll in. On an annual basis, the committee approves revision of some job descriptions. List of job descriptions that the community pays for should not be prohibitive. Then a three year ramp in to a good cadence as to how we hold our senior staff accountable. That way you can do it in management chunks and you never get into a position where job descriptions are wildly outdated. Making sure we have structures in place so that we can support admin as changes are made.

Kathy Kretz: I had the same concerns about the date. We are just getting the kids back in school. Timing of Sept. 1 may not be doable.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: Hearing what member Graham is looking for. With the Sept. 1 deadline, that will overlap with onboarding with new hires. We definitely have nothing to hide. We are in compliance with DESE. We have a platform called Frontline. I would like greater clarity as to what we need to post on the website. Mr. Murphy can speak to that as well.

Dave Murphy: We developed an org chart at the beginning of the year. If the idea is the list of the jobs, I don't have a problem with Sept. 1. If it is job descriptions, it may not be realistic because of our conversations with bargaining partners. This has to get done and it has to get done school. Goal of an org chart is to get to the sub org chart and job descriptions. This is a shared priority and something we need to get to. Ultimately, we need to get to a place where any member can go to the org chart to find the person they are looking for who is responsible for each area. I would say amend it to October 1.

Paul Ruseau: I would say motion to approve with motion to change date to Oct. 1.

Paulette Van der Kloot: I second it. The term professional staff.....are the rest unprofessional?

Dave Murphy: Perhaps permanent staff would be better? Idea is that it is a position that is not specific to one discrete project.

Jenny Graham: Nomenclature comes from existing policy. Permanent is fine.

Motion to approve as amended to Oct. 1 (permanent staff); seconded Paulette Van der Kloot

Jenny Graham, KK, Melanie, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7/0 motion is approved as amended

3. On March 16, 2021, the Education Committee of the Mystic Valley Area NAACP sent the School Committee a letter thanking us for our work this year on the following issues:

- a) The renaming efforts of the Columbus Elementary School.
- b) The end of out-of-school suspensions policy.
- c) The focus on hiring and recruitment of BIPOC candidates to teaching and administrative positions as well as maintaining our current BIPOC staff members.

I request that the letter be entered into the record and would like to read the letter in its entirety.

- *Offered by Paul Ruseau*

[Link to letter here](#)

4. As required by MGL Chapter 71 Section 38M that the School Committee must designate a Student Outreach Coordinator, the School Committee hereby designates Dr. Peter Cushing, Assistant Superintendent of Secondary Education for Medford Public Schools to the role of Student Outreach Coordinator.

- *Offered by Paul Ruseau*

Motion approved. 7/0

Congratulations to Dr. Cushing

3. School Committee Resolution: Condolences:

The Medford School Committee offers its sincere condolences to the family of Edward Michael Hunt, father in law of Rosin Hunt, Administrative Assistant for Athletics.

The Medford School Committee offers its sincere condolences to the family of Therese Sweeney, wife of the late James Sweeney, who was a longtime teacher at Medford High School.

The Medford School Committee offers its sincere condolences to the family of Joan Lee Mullaly, a teacher in the Medford Public Schools for over 30 years.

Motion to adjourn the meeting: /Melanie McLaughlin/Jenny Graham

Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreaz, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot,
Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 7 yes 0 Absent / Payrolls approved